WEEK 7: PROBLEM-SOLVING & COMMUNICATION

The 5-Step Problem-Solving Model

Recovery isn't just about stopping compulsive sexual behavior—it's about developing skills to handle the challenges that trigger that behavior in the first place.

Most men with CSBD struggle with problem-solving. When faced with a difficult situation, they either:

- Avoid it entirely
- React impulsively without thinking
- Ruminate endlessly without taking action
- Turn to sexual behavior as a way to escape

This week, you're learning a structured approach to problem-solving that actually works.

THE 5 STEPS:

STEP 1: DEFINE THE PROBLEM CLEARLY

State the problem as specifically as possible. Avoid vague descriptions.

Vague: "Everything is a mess" **Specific:** "My partner is upset because I came home late three times this week without calling"

Questions to ask:

- What exactly is the problem?
- When does it happen?
- Who is involved?
- What makes it a problem?

STEP 2: BRAINSTORM SOLUTIONS (NO JUDGMENT)

Generate as many possible solutions as you can. Don't evaluate them yet—just get them all out.

The rule: No idea is too ridiculous. Even "bad" ideas can spark good ones.

Example brainstorm:

- Call her every time I'm running late
- Leave work earlier
- Talk to her about realistic expectations
- Quit my job
- Stop going out after work
- Set a phone alarm to remind me to call

STEP 3: EVALUATE PROS AND CONS OF EACH SOLUTION

Now look at each potential solution realistically.

Ask:

- What are the advantages of this solution?
- What are the disadvantages?
- Is this realistic and achievable?
- What resources would I need?
- What might go wrong?

STEP 4: CHOOSE AND IMPLEMENT A SOLUTION

Pick the solution that seems most workable. It doesn't have to be perfect—it just needs to be better than doing nothing.

Make a plan:

- What specific action will I take?
- When will I do it?
- What do I need to make this happen?

STEP 5: EVALUATE THE OUTCOME

After you've tried your solution, assess how it worked.

Ask:

- Did this solve the problem?
- What worked well?
- What didn't work?
- Do I need to try a different solution?
- What did I learn?

If it didn't work: That's data, not failure. Try a different solution from your list.

EXERCISE 1: PROBLEM-SOLVING WORKSHEET

Use this worksheet to work through a current problem you're facing.

STEP 1: DEFINE THE PROBLEM

What is the problem? (Be specific)

_____

_____

_____

When does it happen?

_____

Who is involved?

_____

Why is this a problem for me?

_____

_____

_____

STEP 2: BRAINSTORM SOLUTIONS

List every possible solution you can think of (aim for at least 5-7):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

5. _____

6. _____

7. _____

STEP 3: EVALUATE PROS AND CONS

Choose your top 3 solutions and evaluate each:

Solution #1: _____

Pros: _____

_____

Cons: _____

_____

Solution #2: _____

Pros: _____

_____

Cons: _____

_____

Solution #3: _____

Pros: _____

_____

Cons: _____

_____

_____

STEP 4: CHOOSE AND IMPLEMENT

Which solution will I try first? _____

_____

What specific action will I take?

_____

_____

When will I do this? _____

What do I need to make this happen?

_____

_____

_____

STEP 5: EVALUATE THE OUTCOME

(Complete after trying your solution)

Did this solve the problem? _____

What worked well?

_____

_____

What didn't work?

_____

_____

Do I need to try a different solution? _____

What did I learn from this process?

_____

_____

_____

_____

Common CSBD-Related Problems

Here are problems many men in recovery face. Practice the 5-step model with these scenarios:

SCENARIO 1: "My partner wants to check my phone, and I feel like I'm being treated like a child."

SCENARIO 2: "I feel an urge to act out when I'm alone at home, but I can't avoid being alone."

SCENARIO 3: "My accountability partner keeps canceling on me, and I feel unsupported."

Choose one scenario and work through it using the 5-step model:

Scenario I'm working on: _____

Step 1 - Define the problem:

_____

_____

Step 2 - Brainstorm solutions (at least 5):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Step 3 - Top solution with pros/cons:

Solution: _____

Pros: _____

Cons: _____

Step 4 - My action plan:

_____

_____

_____

Assertive Communication

Most men with CSBD struggle with one of two extremes:

PASSIVE COMMUNICATION:

- Avoiding conflict
- Not expressing needs
- Saying "yes" when you mean "no"
- Letting resentment build

AGGRESSIVE COMMUNICATION:

- Attacking or blaming
- Demanding without listening
- Dismissing others' needs

- Creating more conflict

Neither works. You need ASSERTIVE COMMUNICATION.

ASSERTIVE COMMUNICATION MEANS:

- Expressing your thoughts, feelings, and needs clearly
- Respecting the other person's right to their perspective
- Standing up for yourself without attacking
- Being direct and honest
- Using "I" statements instead of "you" accusations

THE DIFFERENCE:

PASSIVE: "Whatever you want is fine." (Even though you're upset)

AGGRESSIVE: "You never listen to me! You're so selfish!"

ASSERTIVE: "I feel frustrated when my perspective isn't heard. I'd like us to find a solution that works for both of us."

PASSIVE: Says nothing when hurt, acts out sexually later.

AGGRESSIVE: "You're the reason I have this problem!"

ASSERTIVE: "I'm feeling triggered right now, and I need some space to use my coping skills."

Using "I" Statements

"I" statements help you express yourself without blaming or attacking.

THE FORMULA:

"I feel _____ when _____ because _____, and I need _____."

Examples:

"I feel hurt when you criticize me in front of your friends because it feels disrespectful, and I need us to have disagreements privately."

"I feel overwhelmed when you ask me multiple questions about my recovery because I'm still processing it myself, and I need some time before I can talk about it."

"I feel disconnected when we only interact sexually because I need emotional intimacy too, and I'd like us to spend time talking."

EXERCISE 2: PRACTICING "I" STATEMENTS

Convert these "you" statements into "I" statements:

1. "You never support me."

I feel _____

when _____

because _____

and I need _____

---

2. "You're always checking up on me like I'm a child."

I feel _____

when _____

because _____

and I need _____

---

3. "You don't care about my recovery."

I feel _____

when _____

because _____

and I need _____

Now create 3 "I" statements for situations in your own life:

1. I feel _____

when _____

because _____

and I need _____

---

2. I feel _____

when _____

because _____

and I need _____

---

3. I feel _____

when _____

because _____

and I need _____

The DEAR MAN Skill (from DBT)

DEAR MAN is a structured approach to assertive communication from Dialectical Behavior Therapy. It's especially useful for difficult conversations.

D - DESCRIBE the situation State the facts without judgment or interpretation. "You checked my phone last night while I was asleep."

E - EXPRESS your feelings Use "I" statements to share your emotional response. "I feel hurt and mistrusted."

A - ASSERT your needs Clearly state what you want or need. "I need us to talk about boundaries and trust rather than you monitoring me without discussion."

R - REINFORCE positive outcomes Explain the benefits of getting what you're asking for. "If we can build trust through open communication, our relationship will be stronger."

M - STAY MINDFUL Keep your focus on your goal. Don't get sidetracked. If the other person brings up past issues, gently redirect: "I understand that's important, and I want to focus on this specific issue right now."

A - APPEAR CONFIDENT (even if you don't feel it) Use confident body language, maintain eye contact, speak clearly. Acting confident helps you feel more confident.

N - NEGOTIATE Be willing to compromise. Ask what the other person needs too. "What would help you feel more secure without me feeling monitored?"

EXERCISE 3: DEAR MAN PRACTICE

Think of a difficult conversation you need to have. Plan it using DEAR MAN:

DESCRIBE the situation (facts only):

_____

_____

_____

EXPRESS your feelings:

_____

_____

ASSERT your needs:

_____

_____

REINFORCE positive outcomes:

_____

_____

How will you stay MINDFUL?

_____

_____

How will you appear CONFIDENT?

_____

_____

What might you NEGOTIATE?

_____

_____

_____

Setting and Respecting Boundaries

Boundaries are limits you set to protect your wellbeing. They're not walls—they're guidelines for how you want

to be treated.

Types of boundaries:

PHYSICAL BOUNDARIES

- Personal space
- Touch
- Privacy

EMOTIONAL BOUNDARIES

- What you will/won't discuss
- How much emotional energy you give
- Protecting yourself from others' emotions

TIME BOUNDARIES

- How you spend your time
- When you're available
- What commitments you make

SEXUAL BOUNDARIES

- What you're comfortable with sexually
- When and how you engage sexually
- What's off-limits

HOW TO SET A BOUNDARY:

1. Be clear and specific "I'm not comfortable discussing my recovery with extended family yet."

2. Use "I" statements "I need time alone after work to decompress."

3. Don't over-explain or apologize You don't need to justify your boundaries.

4. Be prepared to enforce it If someone violates your boundary, follow through with consequences.

HOW TO RESPECT OTHERS' BOUNDARIES:

1. Listen when someone says "no" Don't argue, pressure, or guilt-trip.

2. Ask permission Don't assume you know what's okay.

3. Accept that their boundaries aren't about you Their limits are about their needs, not your worth.

4. Adjust your behavior If someone sets a boundary, honor it.

EXERCISE 4: MY BOUNDARIES

What boundaries do I need to set?

In my primary relationship:

_____

_____

With my family:

_____

_____

At work:

_____

_____

With friends:

_____

_____

Regarding my recovery:

_____

_____

_____

What boundaries have I violated in the past?

_____

_____

_____

How can I respect others' boundaries better?

_____

_____

_____

Role-Play Practice

This week, practice one difficult conversation with a trusted friend, therapist, or group member.

Choose a conversation you need to have:

Who do I need to talk to? _____

What is the conversation about? _____

Use DEAR MAN to prepare:

D: _____

E: _____

A: _____

R: _____

After the conversation, reflect:

How did it go?

_____

_____

What went well?

_____

_____

What would I do differently next time?

_____

_____

_____

Weekly Communication Log

Track your communication practice this week.

Day	Situation	Type of Communication (Passive/Aggressive/Assertive)	What Happened?	What I Learned
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				

At the end of the week:

Which communication style did I use most often?

When was I most assertive?

When did I struggle to be assertive?

What do I need to practice more?

DAILY MONITORING LOG - WEEK 7

Continue your daily monitoring. This week, add focus on problem-solving and communication.

Additional tracking:

- What problems arose this week?
- How did I handle them?
- Did I communicate assertively?

[7 daily logs with same format as previous weeks—see Appendix A for blank forms]

WEEK 7 HOMEWORK CHECKLIST

Before moving to Week 8, complete:

- [ ] Read all Week 7 material
- [ ] Complete problem-solving worksheet with a real problem
- [ ] Practice problem-solving with one CSBD scenario
- [ ] Practice converting "you" statements to "I" statements
- [ ] Create 3 "I" statements for my own life
- [ ] Prepare one difficult conversation using DEAR MAN
- [ ] Practice assertive communication at least once this week
- [ ] Identify boundaries I need to set
- [ ] Complete weekly communication log
- [ ] Complete daily monitoring logs for all 7 days

Notes for Week 7:

END OF WEEK 7